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Culture (OWC): [Gikuyu \(FL10\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Eastern Africa

Field Date: 1983-1984, 1992, 1994

Coverage Date: 1910-1995

Place Coverage: Mutira, Central Province, Kenya

Section Title(S): 5 Watoro's Story: Poverty Is Like Dust

Nowadays, girls are getting pregnant when they are still at their parents' home. This is because they have no way of knowing when they are grown-up. Girls continue to joke around with younger boys even when they are grown. Now, a boy of my son's age [twelve years old] can abuse me and give no respect. It is not like long ago, when we refused to have any dealings with anybody who was not an agemate. And now, young uncircumcised boys are being called "men" by girls, so they feel grown-up and can joke about with the girls. All this was brought about by school and when we threw away the traditional way of becoming adults through *Irua*.

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I stayed for ten years before I met my husband. During that time I was going to dances and learning how to do things around the homestead and be responsible for the house. During the night, when we were sitting around the fireplace, my grandmother would teach me things I needed to know before marrying. Above all, she said, one should be obedient to one's husband without being stubborn. Also, one must cook good food, and she taught me how to do it. During the day, I was fetching firewood, washing the children in the compound, and helping in the *shamba*.

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I would think about the kind of man I wanted to marry in those days. I wanted a good man who would not wander about, a person who was able to take care of things like the goats and cows at home so that eventually we would be rich and have many things.

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I first met my husband when dancing—that is where people used to meet each other. The men would later escort the girls back to their homesteads—that way, a man came to know where a girl's home was, and if he wanted a certain girl he knew where to find her. That is how my husband came to know my place, because he lived far away from where we were.

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My grandmother had told me that if a man was interested in you, he would come near the granary and start blowing his nose—that is just the way it happened. One day, the husband came near our granary and blew his nose, and I went out to greet him. After talking for some time, we agreed to meet again. We met at my home many times during the next few months, then I decided to have him so I went to my father for tobacco. Later on, the proceedings started for *rūrācio* between our two fathers. I never knew what they agreed that my husband should give, but when we separated he still had not paid anything to my father.

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Human Relations Area Files

755 Prospect Street

New Haven, CT 06511

General Inquiries: ✉ hraf@yale.edu

Issues and Bugs: ✉ hraf-support@yale.edu



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